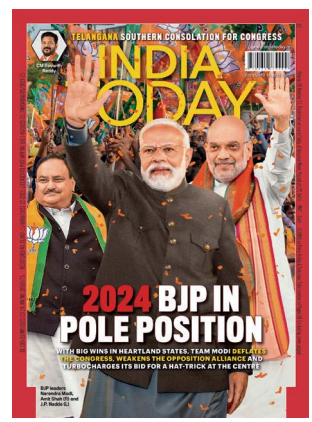
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

It's in character with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's style of doing things that the real surprises come not during elections but after them. After the exit polls, a clean sweep of the three heartland states by the BJP was very much in the realm of possibility. The spring cleaning that followed after that would have left even senior party apparatchiks gasping in disbelief, though. The picture is compelling indeed. A whole class of established politicians stands demonetised, at least for now. And we have a full gallery of mint-new faces entering a rarefied realm even they may not have dared to dream of. Occupying the chief minister's chair in Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan will be people plucked out of grades of anonymity: Vishnu Deo Sai, Mohan Yadav and Bhajan Lal Sharma. In Telangana, A. Revanth Reddy, who led the Congress revival in the state, joined that party in 2017 from the Telugu Desam and was appointed state president as recently as 2021. In Mizoram, sitting chief minister Zoramthanga, who has held office for two terms before, was upset by Lalduhoma who has never held the post. Add all this up and the political landscape crackles with wall-to-wall novelty in the month of December.

The age profile of the newly crowned CMs may not make it seem like a generational change, but it is. Sai is 59, Yadav is a year younger, Sharma is three years younger, and Reddy just turned 54. If you keep out the 1949-born Lalduhoma, a chip of the old block who was in charge of Indira Gandhi's security service, back in his IPS days, we have a crop in its 50s. In the once-comfortably geriatric world of Indian politics, this is indeed young. Remember, the Congress 'new wave' is led by Rahul Gandhi, who is 53.



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But placing this in the context of the coming Lok Sabha election, there is a more urgent logic here than mere age. The BJP has meticulously worked the caste calculus. The picture does not attain full clarity if you see the states in isolation. Put them together, and also toss in the set of two deputy CMs each state has got, and you see all squares in a Rubik's cube being aligned with exacting perfection. Sai is a tribal, in fact, the first Adivasi chief minister Chhattisgarh has seen in 23 years of its existence, after it was carved out as a state specifically to meet tribal aspirations. And Sharma and Yadav, as their canonical surnames reveal, emphatically tick the Brahmin and OBC boxes—the latter with a wide play across states, including Uttar Pradesh.

Zoom in further, and you see the equations balanced out in neat right-angle triangles within each state. Sai has Vijay Sharma and Arun Sao, another Brahmin-OBC combo, as deputy CMs. Yadav has Jagdish Devda, a Dalit, and a third Brahmin in Rajendra Shukla doing the honours in MP. And Sharma's throne in Jaipur has by its side the presence of former local royalty in the form of Diya Kumari, a Rajput and Prem Chand Bairwa, a Dalit. A carefully curated rainbow, then, which ensures the Modi dispensation is seen as empowering politicians from all the disadvantaged sections but without letting go of its core base. That all of them come from the saffron stable also shows how the party has been fastidiously building up a social coalition from below.

In harvesting that crop, the BJP has preferred to let go of names like Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Vasundhara Raje and Raman Singh and all the governance experience they carry. Between the three, definitely not over the hill at 64, 70 and 71, respectively, we are speaking of a full 41 years of chief ministerial experience the party could have fallen back on. By foregoing the tried and tested, it has taken a bold risk. Exactly the sort the Congress shied away from in 2018 when it too had a chance to ring in a generational change. Modi, in line with his penchant for the unexpected, has instead chosen to bet on fresh faces from the saffron stable. Union defence minister Rajnath Singh, sent to Rajasthan as an observer, stood on stage like a last link to the Vajpayee era. But the new faces are hardly random choices, even if they were pulled out like a series of conjurer's tricks. When you see their social profiles, it's more than a thanksgiving for the electoral support the party received from across caste blocs. It's a play for full-spectrum dominance in the general election. Nothing short of a battle formation.

In this week's cover story, we have the task of making the unfamiliar familiar and explaining its seemingly sudden appearance in the spotlight. Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon and Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan give us an insight into Team Modi's strategy of renovation. Executive Editor Kaushik Deka, Deputy Editor Rohit Parihar in Jaipur, Rahul Noronha in Bhopal/Raipur and Menon in Hyderabad give us pen-portraits of the five new CMs, their political journey, their credo and, most of all, the daunting challenges before them. These are not inconsiderable: Reddy and the three BJP CMs have to deliver a promised cornucopia of freebies while staying fiscally fit.

They also offer us fascinating slices of India's political life at the ground level. Sai comes from a political family: his uncle was an old Jan Sanghi, a two-time MLA and a Union minister in the Janata government of 1977-80. But Sai earned his spurs literally at the grassroots, working in the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram and being elected as a panch in 1989 before being taken under the wings of 'ghar wapsi' pioneer Dilip Singh Judeo and rising to be an MP, Union minister and then state BJP chief. When the high command's roulette wheel needle stopped at Yadav's name in MP, it had bypassed a who's who of state politics; the Ujjain native had to literally step up from the back benches. This son of a bhajiya and poha stall-owner is dyed-in-the-wool BJP stock, having cut his teeth in the hurly-burly of student politics as an ABVP member, then lending his muscle to the RSS and slowly working his way into formal politics. His weighty academic record (B.Sc., LLB, MBA, MA, Ph.D.) backed his appointment as state higher education minister in 2020, during which time he was by all accounts an eager beaver. The prize surprise was Sharma of Rajasthan but his Sangh credentials are impeccable.

These winds of change, therefore, come with a strong whiff of continuity. Think of it as a clarion call for the 2024 general election.

(Aroon Purie)